The March of the Flag

Sen. Albert J. Beveridge (R-IN) · campaign speech · September 16, 1898 · excerpts

Source: Albert J. Beveridge, 'The March of the Flag' (Sept. 16, 1898), text via Teaching American History. Public domain.

Delivered during the Spanish-American War campaign in Indianapolis, Beveridge's speech is a blunt expression of late-19th-century American imperialism. He argued for permanent U.S. control of Cuba, Puerto Rico, and the Philippines on the grounds of providence, racial superiority, and economic necessity. The speech makes the racial assumptions of expansionists in the 1898 debate impossible to ignore.

Connect: Beveridge's racial framing of 'destiny' echoes O'Sullivan's 'manifest destiny' (Class 16) from 50 years earlier. What continues? What's new about 1890s imperialism?

Key Passages

On destiny

> It is a glorious history our God has bestowed upon His chosen people … a history heroic with faith in our mission and our future; a history of statesmen who flung the boundaries of the Republic out into unexplored lands and savage wildernesses; a history of soldiers who carried the flag across the blazing deserts and through the ranks of hostile mountains, even to the gates of sunset

The march of the flag

> Or that we are of the ruling race of the world; that ours is the blood of government; ours the heart of dominion; ours the brain and the genius of administration? We do but what our fathers did—but pitch the tents of liberty farther westward, farther southward—we only continue the march of the flag.

On markets

> But, today, we are raising more than we can consume. Today, we are making more than we can use. . . . Therefore, we must find new markets for our produce, new occupation for our capital, new work for our labor.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Spanish-American War (1898): the U.S. had won quickly and was debating whether to keep the Philippines, Puerto Rico, and other islands.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Indiana voters at a Republican campaign rally (1898 midterm elections), and the national public via newspaper reprints.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Albert Beveridge, a young Republican politician and expansionist who believed in Anglo-Saxon superiority; Filipino and Cuban views are absent.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. LEQ Thesis (1 pt): Write a defensible thesis arguing whether U.S. imperialism after 1898 represented a continuity with — or a break from — earlier American expansion.
2. Identify the THREE distinct justifications Beveridge offers and rank them by force of argument.
3. How might an Anti-Imperialist League member (e.g., Mark Twain) have rebutted each?

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> An Indiana Senate candidate's rousing case for American imperialism after the Spanish-American War: annex the Philippines, Hawaii, and Puerto Rico as a God-given duty — and set aside "consent of the governed" for peoples he deemed unready.

On destiny

Fellow citizens, it is a noble land that God has given us; a land that can feed and clothe the world; a land whose coastlines would enclose half the countries of Europe; a land set like a sentinel between the two imperial oceans of the globe, a greater England with a nobler destiny. It is a mighty people that He has planted on this soil; a people sprung from the most masterful blood of history; a people perpetually revitalized by the virile, man-producing workingfolk of all the earth; a people imperial by virtue of their power, by right of their institutions, by authority of their heaven-directed purposes—the propagandists and not the misers of liberty. It is a glorious history our God has bestowed upon His chosen people; a history whose keynote was struck by [the] Liberty Bell; a history heroic with faith in our mission and our future; a history of statesmen who flung the boundaries of the Republic out into unexplored lands and savage wildernesses; a history of soldiers who carried the flag across the blazing deserts and through the ranks of hostile mountains, even to the gates of sunset; a history of a multiplying people who overran a continent in half a century; a history of prophets who saw the consequences of evils inherited from the past and of martyrs who died to save us from them; a history divinely logical, in the process of whose tremendous reasoning we find ourselves today.

[. . .]

On consent of the governed

The opposition tells us that we ought not to govern a people without their consent. I answer, the rule of liberty that all just government derives its authority from the consent of the governed, applies only to those who are capable of self-government. We govern the Indians without their consent, we govern our territories without their consent, we govern our children without their consent. How do they know what our government would be without their consent? Would not the people of the Philippines prefer the just, humane, civilizing government of this Republic to the savage, bloody rule of pillage and extortion from which we have rescued them? Do not the blazing fires of joy and the ringing bells of gladness in Puerto Rico prove the welcome of our flag? And, regardless of this formula of words made only for enlightened, self-governing peoples, do we owe no duty to the world? Shall we turn these peoples back to the reeking hands from which we have taken them? Shall we abandon them to their fate with the wolves of conquest all about them? Shall we save them from those nations, to give them a self-rule of tragedy? It would be like giving a razor to a babe and telling it to shave itself.

[. . .]

On the ruling race

Will you say by your vote that American ability to govern has decayed, that you are an infidel to American vigor and practical sense? Or that we are of the ruling race of the world; that ours is the blood of government; ours the heart of dominion; ours the brain and the genius of administration? We do but what our fathers did—but pitch the tents of liberty farther westward, farther southward—we only continue the march of the flag.

[. . .]

On markets

But, today, we are raising more than we can consume. Today, we are making more than we can use. . . . Therefore, we must find new markets for our produce, new occupation for our capital, new work for our labor. And so, while we did not need the territory taken during the past century at the time it was acquired, we do need what we have taken in 1898, and we need it now.

[. . .]

On providence

His great purposes are revealed in the progress of the flag, which surpasses the intentions of Congresses and cabinets, and leads us, like a holier pillar of cloud by day and pillar of fire by night, into situations unforeseen by finite wisdom and duties unexpected by the unprophetic heart of selfishness. The American people cannot use a dishonest medium of exchange; it is ours to set the world its example of right and honor. We cannot fly from our world duties; it is ours to execute the purpose of a fate that has driven us to be greater than our small intentions. We cannot retreat from any soil where Providence has unfurled our banner; it is ours to save that soil for liberty and civilization. For liberty and civilization and God's promises fulfilled, the flag must henceforth be the symbol and the sign to all mankind.

Words to know

sentinel — a guard standing watch

propagandists — active spreaders of an idea (here, liberty), not hoarders of it

consent of the governed — the Declaration's principle that just government needs the people's agreement

pillage and extortion — looting and forcing payment by threats, Beveridge's description of Spanish rule

dominion — ruling power over territory and people

Providence — God's guiding plan for events